reforms. The main actors in this movement were Kang Youwei (1858–1927), Liang Qichao (1873–1929) and Tan Sitong (1865–98). They are associated with the brief ‘100 Days of Reform’ (June–September 1898) when the Qing emperor Guang Xu attempted to introduce some key reforms suggested by Kang Youwei and others. Kang’s ideas included parliamentary government, constitutional monarchy, abolition of the civil service examination and its replacement by a system of recruitment that emphasized modern disciplines and, much more controversially, commitment to an eventual world government with boundaries ceasing to exist. These reforms proved too radical for the deeply conservative and entrenched palace bureaucracy. Senior Manchu officials reacted with unmitigated hostility and convinced Dowager Empress Cixi to reject such subversive ideas and radical institutional changes. The emperor Guang Xu was detained, and Kang and Liang went into exile in Japan. Tan Sitong was executed. However, Kang’s ideas became part of the running discourse on China’s transition towards modernity.

Although China was defeated by Japan, the victor was at the same time held up as a model of an Asian country having successfully dealt with the Western challenge. There was a steady stream of Chinese intellectuals and scholars visiting and living in Japan to learn about the Japanese experience with modernity. It is the threat of violent attack by the ships led by the American Commodore Perry which had led to the opening up of Japan to external trade. The Treaty of Kanagawa concluded in 1854 was the outcome of Perry’s aggressive naval posturing along Japan’s coast. This accelerated a trend that was already visible in Japan – to gain knowledge of and familiarity with the West. For example, the Institute for the Investigation of Barbarian Books, which was in charge of translating a large volume of Western texts, was established as early as in 1811, and in 1857 became the School of Western Knowledge and Languages. The Shogunate, or the ruling aristocracy, was overthrown in 1868. This marked the Meiji Restoration, when the emperor began to rule again, but as a constitutional monarch. The Meiji Restoration inaugurated a period of thoroughgoing institutional and economic reform modelled on the West. Japan’s leaders recognized that in